



powerful
limbs for tree
climbing



American black bear

Ursus americanus

Smaller than grizzlies, black bears also have a straighter profile and are much better climbers. They prefer temperate forests, but can cope with humid Florida swamps as well as subarctic weather in Canada. True omnivores, they mainly feed on wild fruits, nuts, and vegetation, supplemented with insects, grubs, fish, and carrion—occasionally they hunt mammals too. Inquisitive and opportunistic, black bears also exploit garbage dumps and food left at campsites.

They are solitary except during the mating season, which takes place from mid-May to July. The cubs are born in a den from January to March, while their mothers are hibernating. Litters are usually made up of twins or triplets, but can contain as many as four or five cubs. Cubs remain with their mothers until they are around two years old.

Healthy numbers

American black bear numbers are about twice those of all the world's other bear species combined—despite the fact that it is native to just three countries: Canada, the US, and Mexico. Of 16 recognized subspecies, only the smallest, the Louisiana black bear (*U.a. luteolus*), is considered threatened under the US Endangered Species Act, due mainly to habitat loss and overhunting. The population of black bears seems stable in areas that are as diverse as their coat colors, which range from cinnamon, light gold, gray-blue, dark brown, and black to British Columbia's white-Kermode or "spirit bear" subspecies (*U.a. kermodei*).



△ SCRATCH MY BACK

Black bears often use trees as scratching posts, but bite and claw marks left on bark may mean certain trees also serve a territorial scent-marking purpose.



△ BATTLE WORN

Black bears are shy and generally avoid humans, but both sexes will fight, kill, and sometimes even eat each other.

◁ TREE CLIMBING

Cubs are taught by their mothers to climb trees to escape danger—including attacks by adult male black bears.

A black bear's **sense of smell** is **seven** times more **acute** than a **bloodhound's**